

# HEART FOR THE HOUSE

**Blue denotes PPT slide**

**Brown denotes instructions to technician**

**TEXT:** Isaiah 54:1-8 (LB) *“Sing, O childless woman! Break out into loud and joyful song, Jerusalem, for she who was abandoned has more blessings now than she whose husband stayed! 2 Enlarge your house; build on additions; spread out your home! 3 For you will soon be bursting at the seams! And your descendants will possess the cities left behind during the exile and rule the nations that took their lands. 4 Fear not; you will no longer live in shame. The shame of your youth and the sorrows of widowhood will be remembered no more, 5 for your Creator will be your “husband.” The Lord Almighty is his name; he is your Redeemer, the Holy One of Israel, the God of all the earth. 6 For the*

*Lord has called you back from your grief—  
a young wife abandoned by her husband.  
7 For a brief moment I abandoned you.  
But with great compassion I will take you  
back. 8 In a moment of anger I turned my  
face a little while; but with everlasting love  
I will have pity on you, says the Lord, your  
Redeemer.”*

**INTRO:** The next three weeks we are going to be looking at Isaiah 54 through the lens of having a **“Heart For The House”**.

- A heart for God’s house...
- A heart for others house...
- A heart for our house...

The order in which I have chosen to preach these three topics is intentional, not accidental. We all know that establishing the right priorities in life is essential but the world we live in is constantly attempting to scramble our priorities. Right priorities should look like this:

- God...
- Others...
- Ourselves...

## **A HEART FOR GOD'S HOUSE**

(Leave on screen until next slide)

Isaiah 53 is the lament by the prophet Isaiah concerning the captivity of Israel and what is best known as “*The suffering servant*”.

In this passage of scripture Israel had been carried into Babylonian captivity. Have you experienced captivity? In what areas have you experienced captivity?

- Marriage?
- Family?
- Career?
- Spiritual Life?

The captivity of Israel was not just a bump in the road, it lasted seventy years and involved slavery.

The reason they were in captivity to begin with was because they allowed their priorities to become scrambled. They fell into sin, and out of the favor of God.

The same thing happens to us when we allow the world to distort our priorities. When this occurs it is not long until our lives are completely out of kilter and large amounts of our time, talent, and treasure are being invested in directions we never intended to go. [Stephen R. Covey](#) said, *“Most of us spend too much time on what is urgent and not enough time on what is important.”* (Leave on screen until next slide)

Isaiah 54 begins by utilizing the example of a childless woman. In that culture it was believed that if a woman had no children it was because God was chastising her for sinful behavior. We know better, but this is what they believed. In this passage Israel is

the childless woman and they had been banished from their land for seventy years because of their sin.

In Isaiah 54 Israel was about to be reunited with her homeland because she had recognized the error of her ways, and had turned back to God! Good things happen when we recalibrate our priorities. The recalibration of priorities can be difficult to say the least, because it first requires us to admit we are off track. It also necessitates a plan to set things back in order. Setting things back in order can be painful to say the least. [Dallin H. Oaks](#) said, *“Desires dictate our priorities, priorities shape our choices, and choices determine our actions.”* (Leave on screen until next slide)

The next three Sunday's we are going to do just that as a church and we are going to see God turn things around:

- At God's house...

- At others house...
- At our house...

Listen to the words of hope in verse one;  
*“Sing, O childless woman! Break out into loud and joyful song, Jerusalem, for she who was abandoned has more blessings now than she whose husband stayed!”*

(Leave on screen until next slide)

Before her exile, Israel had allowed her land to fall into a deplorable state of disrepair.

This occurred because of misaligned priorities. Misaligned priorities can happen:

(Place on screen one at a time)

- In our marriage...
- While raising children...
- On our career path...
- At our church...

The Lord spoke to me one day and said,  
*“The proof of desire is pursuit.”*

I understand that our bodies are “*The temple of the Holy Spirit*” but we also have a responsibility toward the building and facility where we choose to meet in corporate worship and instruction. This place is hallowed because we have consecrated it for worship, instruction, and service to the Lord.

I am calling us as a body of believers to focus today on what we can do to realign our priorities by putting God’s house first.

Talk about the sacrifices the Houston campus has made to give birth to all the other venues – Espanol, Pasadena, Gulfgate, Sugar Land & Legacy

We have come together to put God’s house first. Putting God’s house first looks like this:

- Outreaches – Health fairs, food fairs, free fairs, door to door evangelism... Ten's of thousands have been reached.
- Schools – Between daycares and charter schools we currently have close to 1,000 children enrolled.

Today we are introducing the ***Heart For The House Campaign***. Over the next few weeks we are going to be spotlighting **three areas that need our attention and resources:** (Place on screen one at a time & Leave all three up until end of service)

- **Empowerment Conference** – Each year CT brings several hundred ministers from all over the world to the Empowerment Conference – We pay for three nights lodging, meals, and registration for these church leaders – Purpose? To pour into the very people who spend their lives pouring out into the Kingdom of God – Most of the leaders who attend are serving in small,

economically challenged places and could not attend without a scholarship – They go home recharged spiritually and resourced for ministry – In the words of one participant *“I came to Empowerment so discouraged I was contemplating giving up but I returned to my church with new vision, ideas, and resources. We have implemented much of what we were taught and our church is seeing amazing results.”* Budget \$50,000

- **Renovation** – Nursery building (Paint and floor covering) – Children’s area in Family Life Center (Paint, floor covering, and minor renovations) – Gym (New sound system and sound booth remodeling) Sanctuary renovation (Stage face lift) – Budget \$50,000
- **Project Houston Community Development Corporation** - Health fairs, food fairs, free fairs - Ten’s of thousands have been reached -Charter schools and

daycares – Between charter schools and daycares we currently have close to 1,000 children enrolled - Budget \$50,000

Our overall goal is \$150,000 by the end of September. *All Heart For the House* funds will be distributed in the following manner: (Place on screen one at a time and leave on screen until end of service)

- First \$50,000 will go to Empowerment Conference...
- Second \$50,000 will go to church renovations...
- Third \$50,000 will go to Project Houston CDC...

As we fill out our faith promise cards I want us to make a notation on the back of the prayer card naming the seed we are sowing. No farmer sows a seed without identifying it first. We should never sow a financial seed without naming the seed. The prayer cards

will be prayed over in staff meeting each week, and they will also be prayed over at each Sunday morning service between now and the end of September.

Will you join me in putting God's house first today?

### **A HEART FOR OTHERS HOUSE**

It is interesting to me that Isaiah does not just prophesy freedom and blessing over his house, his prophecy is over the entire nation of Israel.

Isaiah and his family would most certainly become beneficiaries of the fulfilled prophecy, but the scope of this word was much bigger than one family or tribe. Sometimes it is difficult for us to get focused on what someone else needs because we have issues that are looming bigger than life.

The Dead Sea is called the Dead Sea because it has many contributories but no outflow. The reason it is called the Dead Sea is because it is incapable of sustaining marine life. Someone said, *“God will give it to you, if He can get it through you.”* A “me” mentality is the archenemy of a “we” mentality. The only way to accomplish a God sized vision is through a “we” mentality. God never intended for any of us to hole up in a self-imposed cocoon, and live our lives selfishly. God designed us to live our lives with other people. [Genesis 2:18 \(NKJV\)](#) *“God said, It is not good that man should be alone; I will make him a helper comparable to him.”*

Our lives will never become what God intended as long as we insist on a “me” mentality. Our vision will never become a reality until we embrace a “we” mentality.

[Elizabeth Elliott](#) said, *“The will of God is*

*not something you add to your life. It's a course you choose. You either line yourself up with the Son of God, or you capitulate to the principle which governs the rest of the world."* (Leave on screen until next slide)

In order to do this we must put God first, others second, and ourselves third. By properly prioritizing our lives in this way, our priorities become a surge protector for our pride and power gifts.

The number one hurdle to getting blessed is to have the faith to sow seed outside of our four walls. Listen to the words of Jesus.

*Luke 6:38 "Give, and it shall be given unto you; good measure, pressed down, and shaken together, and running over, shall men give into your bosom. For with the same measure that ye mete withal it shall be measured to you again."* (Leave on screen until finished with bullet points)

Look at this:

- You cannot get until you give... (That doesn't make sense, yet it is a spiritual and Biblical principle that works – If you are in need, GIVE!)
- If you give, God will cause MEN to give to you... (When we give we expect God to bless us, but here He says He will cause MEN to give to us!)
- Our blessing is commensurate to the size of our gift... (Use a teaspoon, a ladle, and a scoop shovel to illustrate this – If you need a little blessing, give a little gift – If you need a BIG blessing, give a BIG gift)

The correct prioritization of our heart is:

- God...
- Others...
- Us...

The correct prioritization of our resources is:

- God...

- Others...
- Us...

Whether it is a church or an individual, **how we spend our resources is a reflection of our heart.** (Leave on screen until next slide)

John Bunyan said, *“You have not lived today until you have done something for someone who can never repay you.”*

Prioritization of resources has been a consistent theme of CT efforts and resources over the past several years. **Since 2013 CT has seen the following results:** (Place on screen one at a time)

- More than 3,650 salvations...
- More than 1,000,000 pounds of food distributed...
- More than 92,000 people served in food fairs...
- More than 45,000 people served through our Health Fairs....

- We have saved the community more than \$742,000 through our Health Fairs and Food Fairs....
- We save our community approximately \$150,000 annually through our Free Fairs...
- Live Well family Services has 38 life coaches, and their volunteer efforts saves our community more than \$75,000 annually...

All this takes about 10,000 volunteer hours annually. The volunteer hours does not include all those who volunteer inside the church working with children, youth, ushers, greeters, music, etc... I feel very safe to say, the people of CT Church invest more than 25,000 volunteer hours every year.

John Holmes said, *“There is no exercise better for the heart than reaching down and lifting people up.”*

Now that is the kind of church I want to attend, contribute to, and invest in.

Today we are asking you to commit to the ***Heart For The House*** campaign. Over the next couple weeks we are going to be spotlighting **three areas that need our attention and resources:**

- **Empowerment Conference** – Each year CT brings several hundred ministers from all over the world to the Empowerment Conference – We pay for three nights lodging, meals, and registration for these church leaders – Purpose? To pour into the very people who spend their lives pouring out into the Kingdom of God – Most of the leaders who attend are serving in small, economically challenged places and could not attend without a scholarship – They go home recharged spiritually and resourced for ministry – In the words of one participant *“I came to*

*Empowerment so discouraged I was contemplating giving up but I returned to my church with new vision, ideas, and resources. We have implemented much of what we were taught and our church is seeing amazing results.” Budget \$50,000*

- **Renovations** – Nursery building (Paint and floor covering) – Children’s area in Family Life Center (Paint, floor covering, and minor renovations) – Gym (New sound system and sound booth remodeling) Sanctuary renovation (Stage face lift) – Budget \$50,000
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As we fill out our faith promise cards I want us to make a notation on the back of the prayer card naming the seed we are sowing. No farmer sows a seed without identifying it first. We should never sow a financial seed without naming the seed. The prayer cards will be prayed over in staff meeting each week and at each Sunday morning service between now and the end of September.

**A HEART FOR OUR HOUSE**

In Isaiah 54 the seventy years of captivity was coming to an end for the Israelites. They had realigned their priorities and as a result they were about to experience the exponential blessings of the Lord. The message of this passage is primarily to a nation but look how personal it becomes: (Place on screen one at a time)

- The mourning woman gets her song back... Vs. 1, ***“Break out into loud and joyful song”*** The Word declares, ***“Weeping may endure for a night, but joy comes in the morning.”*** When we get our priorities right we can say GOOD MORNING! The LONG night has ended and morning has dawned.
- Full redemption is made to her... Vs. 1, ***“She who was abandoned has more blessings now than she whose husband stayed!”*** When our priorities are in order those who have been living on one income can experience more blessings than those who have two incomes.

- Promises of exponential blessing... Vs. 2 & 3, ***“Enlarge your house; build on additions; spread out your home! 3 For you will soon be bursting at the seams!”*** When we get our house in order and our priorities proper aligned we can get ready, get ready, get ready because the blessings and expansion are going to be off the chain.
- The blessing to future generations... Vs. 3, ***“And your descendants will possess the cities left behind during the exile and rule the nations that took their lands.”*** What we do here and now will affect our descendants and future generations.
- Fear and shame will be annihilated... Vs. 4, ***“Fear not; you will no longer live in shame. The shame of your youth and the sorrows of widowhood will be remembered no more.”*** When we get our priorities right the shame of past failures fade into the distance.

- The Lord will be our partner... Vs. 5-7,  
*“Your Creator will be your “husband.” The Lord Almighty is his name; he is your Redeemer, the Holy One of Israel, the God of all the earth. 6 For the Lord has called you back from your grief—a young wife abandoned by her husband. 7 For a brief moment I abandoned you. But with great compassion I will take you back. 8 In a moment of anger I turned my face a little while; but with everlasting love I will have pity on you, says the Lord, your Redeemer.”* D.L. Moody said, *“If God be your partner, make your plans big.”* It is time for us to go big or go home!

Are we ready for God to show up at our house and bring about some much-needed miracles? If so, we must be willing to sow seed outside our four walls. We must release the my-four-and-no-more mentality and firmly grip the hand of God by sowing what

you cannot afford to sow. Someone said, “*If it wont meet your need, make it your seed!*”

Today we are asking you to commit to the ***Heart For The House*** campaign. Today we are giving you an opportunity to invest in one of three areas: (Place on screen one at a time)

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